So in February 1917, Pandit Malaviyaji asked for leave to introduce a bill for the immediate abolition of the system. Lord Chelmsford refused permission. It was time for me to tour the country for an all-India agitation.

Before I started the agitation I thought it proper to wait upon the Viceroy. So I applied for an interview. He immediately granted it. Mr Maffey, now Sir John Maffey, was his private secretary. I came in close contact with him. I had a satisfactory talk with Lord Chelmsford who, without being definite, promised to be helpful.

I began my tour from Bombay. Mr Jehangir Petit undertook to convene the meeting under the auspices of the Imperial Citizenship Association. The Executive Committee of the Association met first for framing the resolutions to be moved at the meeting. Dr Stanley Reed, Sjt (now Sir) Lallubhai Samaldas, Sjt Natarajan and Mr Petit were present at the Committee meeting. The discussion centred round the fixing of the period within which the Government was to be asked to abolish the system. There were three proposals, viz. for abolition ‘as soon as possible’, abolition ‘by 31 July’, and ‘immediate abolition’. I was for a definite date, as we could then decide what to do if the Government failed to accede to our request within the time limit. Sjt Lallubhai was for ‘immediate’ abolition. He said ‘immediate’ indicated a shorter period than 31 July. I explained that the people would not understand the word ‘immediate’. If we wanted to get them to do something, they must have a more definite word. Everyone would interpret ‘immediate’ in his own way –